

Toast to the One We Lost

“Still can you call me aunt, but I no longer have a father to call mine.”

Mingled with a tinge of jealousy, even hatred, it was the first sentence that my aunt spat at me upon my return to our hometown for grandfather’s funeral.

Soft as a spring breeze, not a single second did her show me a hint of coldness—except for this moment. I didn’t know how to respond to such a word, just standing rooted as a wood, seeing her hollow red-rimmed eyes slowly approaching, and drifting away.

“Hey,” Mom whispered, breaking my trance with a touch on my shoulder. “Time to go”.

I nodded slightly, straightened my black armband, and stepped into the shabby cottage where Grandpa’s life had begun—and ended.

Cramped at the best of times, the hut felt even more suffocating with the inky black coffin at its center and the heavy air of grief diffusing around. Kneeling on the bamboo mat, the chill of the stone floor seeped through my bones. I stared at the doorway, bracing for the ritual.

The first mourner staggered in—a frail woman, her husband’s arm her crutch. “Why, why, why?” she wailed, her voice a frayed thread.

It was the first fallen domino.

One by one, mourners shuffled through the threshold: flushed faces, piercing panting, shivering shoulders. Though many of us were strangers, all of us were now the victims drowning in the sea of bereavement, and losers collapsed under the sickle of death.

The deeper the bond, the sharper the wound. This truth clung my ribs as I watched my father. That man—stern, stoic, a monolith—crumbled. He wept into my mother’s shoulder, with tears carving rivers through his stoicism.

From dawn to dusk, his sorrow mirrored the sky: gray, unrelenting, a Funeral shroud. When we carried the ashes uphill for burial, the clouds opened. Raindrops

tangled in his hair, drenched the eulogy, kissed the gravestone, and finally dissolved into the wine he clutched like an anchor.

“First toast,” the elder intoned, “to heaven and earth.”

The incense lifted, a wisp of warmth, fleeting as a heartbeat.

“Second toast,” he continued, “to the gods and ghosts.”

The liquor drifted, a winding road, heading to the unseen.

“Third toast,” he said, “to the dead and to the living.”

The silence burned, a flaring cold.

Heaven and earth are ageless, ghosts and gods are undying, but we, the living, are losing all the time. The rain we bath would be over, the wine we drank would be emptied, and the person we loved would be lost forever. Nevertheless, the time spent with them left, the memories shared together kept, and they went further than our lives.